

Triggers & *Patterns*

TRIGGER → REACTION → PATTERN

Working with triggers is about noticing the spark. Working with patterns is about healing the habitual cycle that follows

Something happens. The trigger fires.

It might be a tone of voice, a word, being ignored, feeling criticised, being needed too much - or not enough. The emotion arrives fast and hard, often bigger than the moment seems to call for.



What sets you off?



The reaction kicks in before you can think

You shut down, lash out, go quiet, over-explain, people-please, withdraw. This is your nervous system doing what it learned to do. It is not a character flaw. It is a survival response



What does the reaction look like?



Finding the original wound



The pattern takes over

The same story runs. The same dynamic plays out. Different situation, same feeling. You recognise it - sometimes only in hindsight - as something familiar



Noticing the pattern



The gap is where the work lives

Between the trigger and the reaction, there is a moment. It may be tiny. But it is there. Learning to find that moment - and pause in it - is how patterns begin to change



Pause, name, breathe and regulate

The Fire

A pattern is a recurring way you think, feel, or behave once you have been triggered - often looping across situations or relationships. It is the story or cycle that develops around your triggers. What happens again and again until it feels automatic. The pattern reignites the fire.

The Spark

A trigger is a **stimulus** - external or internal - that activates an emotional reaction, often disproportionately intense compared to the situation at hand. It is the flare-up of raw emotion that points towards something deeper. The trigger is the match being struck.

Your Anchor

*"The pattern is not who you are.
It is what you learned"*

You learned it because it kept you safe. You are here because you are ready to learn something different. That is not a weakness. That is the bravest thing a person can do.